

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world Global Warming

Fighting for the EARTH

AL GORE The former US Vice-President was one of first doomsayers of global warming. He's won a Nobel, an Oscar and now travels the world, creating awareness about global warming and climate change.



R.K. PACHAURI The chairman of the IPCC has become synonymous with climate change. Under him, the IPCC drafted its fourth assessment report, the largest and the most detailed summary of the climate change situation.



SUNITA NARAIN The director of the Centre for Science and Environment made a mark by taking on the powerful cola giants over high pesticide levels in soft drinks in 2003. Since then Narain has also played a role in shaping the Government's policy on climate change.



MEDHA PATKAR She is a veteran of many fasts, jail terms and police beatings for spearheading the Narmada Bachao Andolan, a people's movement against a major hydroelectric project on the Narmada river. She has recently taken on the issue of illegal mining in Karnataka's Bellary district.



ernment that as a matter of policy would not say the words "global warming". When Green parties or movements squeezed themselves into power, mostly in Europe, they found the going rough. But they had surprising successes: in Liberia, it was banning the illegal tropical timber trade that toppled dictator Charles Taylor. And they kept going. By the end of the decade, the connections between green movements north and south, east and west, were far stronger than ever before, and issues of environmental sustainability had more market share in the media than ever before. Global warming was, in many ways, the UN's new signature issue.

And slowly, a new economic vision was being born. While in the US, the government spent most of the decade trying to pretend that environmental concerns did not exist, at the state and local level, innovation flourished. A thousand cities pledged to meet the Copenhagen carbon reduction goals, even if the nation would not sign. Eighty per cent of the proposed coal-fired power plants were stopped or withdrawn, and the rest mostly remained in limbo. Driven by pressure from consumers, the price of oil, and the states, auto manufacturers finally agreed to reduce the amount of gasoline their vehicles need by 40 per cent. The US built more wind power than coal.

China started investing heavily in green

tech, first wind turbines and battery technology and then piled on, so that by the decade's end, it was far outstripping Europe and the US in the new economic race. Brazil and South Korea picked their leadership sectors in the global green economy. Abu Dhabi looked ahead to the day when its oil runs out and began a carbon neutral city in the desert to make it a clean tech model for the world. India recognised that in a world dependent on carbon, nations like itself don't do well and that it was foolish to leave itself open to a world controlled not only by OPEC but by a nascent OCEC (Organisation of Coal Exporting Countries) as well.

By the end of the decade, it was still true that for powering big cities, coal plants were cheaper in the short term—and until the price spikes—than wind or solar. Google was still earnestly pursuing a future in which R<C (renewable energy is cheaper than coal). But entrepreneurs were on the verge of realising that two billion people in the world light their homes with kerosene, not electricity, and that for them, solar lights are already cheaper and more reliable than the fossil fuels. We can finish lighting the world for almost nothing. R<C is already here.

The plight of Indonesia's vanishing forests was on the world's agenda and it seemed possible that the global community would begin to understand that if those

Green LINE

2001 Delhi's public transport fleet becomes the largest in the world to switch to environment-friendly CNG.

2005 The Kyoto Protocol comes into force, setting binding targets for industrialised countries on reduction of greenhouse gas emissions.

